

STARTUP ZONE

Product Development Process: The Difference A Partner's Support Can Make

The path that needs to be followed to take a new product from concept to the customer is full of hurdles. Partnering with product development experts, who help through the many phases of launching a cutting-edge, relevant product in the market, makes the journey easier.

Today, when ideas have immense power to transform the world, the journey from ideation to execution is significant. Whether a company is already established or is a startup, it is always looking to stay relevant in the market through innovation, by researching new technologies,

developers. So, it is advisable to have some kind of partner operating at whatever level support is needed.

Such support could be at the very beginning of a concept's journey—for example, researching the market to see if there is even a need for the product. At the other end of the process, support could be for designing packaging, organising distribution and even telling the world about the product, through marketing and public relations.

The figure below shows the stages of an electronic product's creation and development process. So, how

with concept development and market penetration adds the necessary perspective.

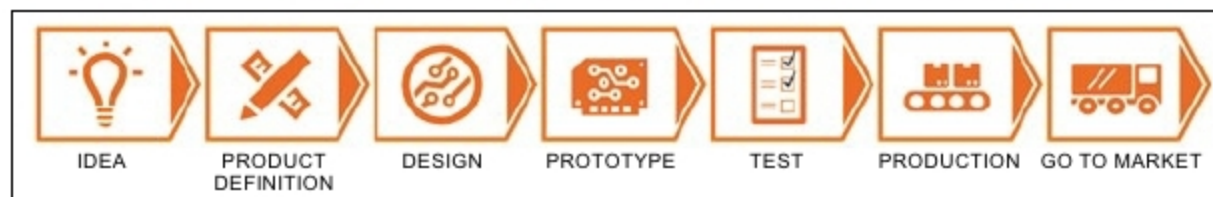
Alternatively, to accelerate the whole initial product development process, there are several mentoring programmes that provide access to a network of business mentors, investors, hardware professionals and even potential customers. This type of service is particularly ideal for startups that hope to receive financial support to take things to the next level—being introduced to mentors can make a massive difference to the outcome of any product development exercise.

At the same time, an initial consultation with an application engineer can put many fears and doubts to rest, and bring clarity to a potentially bewildering process. A crucial question that needs to be addressed at the product definition stage is whether there is actually a requirement for such a product, and whether it has the potential to generate interest among consumers.

Turning idea into design

Translating the idea into a design is the next step. It is important to carry out a feasibility study before committing too much time and money to any project. A detailed product development plan should be generated by taking help from specialists and professionals who are well versed in providing engineering solutions to hobbyists, startups and established businesses, while also looking into how the whole development programme is to be funded. Unless these vital elements are in place, going any further is not advisable.

Also, when it comes to choosing the correct products for an application, the right partner with up-to-date product and design experience can help a startup determine something as fundamental as whether a field-programmable gate array is the best technology to adopt, or whether a



Premier Farnell's maker-to-market process

creating new electronic products or developing existing projects further. All of this depends on how an idea that has enormous commercial potential is developed, such that the finished product grabs the attention of those who will welcome its creation, reap its benefits, and order and use it in vast quantities.

With the range of development boards, open source hardware and software libraries available, as well as the growth of cloud services, the process of taking an idea all the way from proof-of-concept stage to the market is no longer the domain of large, well-funded organisations. Makers, hobbyists and tinkerers are now just as likely to become full-fledged professional

can third-party support make a difference between success and failure?

Brainstorm and ideate

Whether the initial concept is generated by a hobbyist, a startup company or an established business, it always helps to talk to others in similar situations. Online communities, such as the one built by element14 (www.element14.com/community/welcome), are ideal platforms for inventors and creators to discuss the pitfalls of bringing a concept to market. Of course, this should be done without revealing the details of the original idea.

A second opinion from people who are facing the same challenges